THE MOOKERJEE ALTERNATIVE

If Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel pursued his beliefs and commitments while functioning within the government, that was not the case with his contemporary Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee. There are many facets to his contributions that are worthy of discussion. After all, he was a notable educationist, an influential political personality, a leader in providing humanitarian relief and an ardent espouser of our culture and traditions. Above all, he was a fierce nationalist and one quintessentially Indian, who approached his nation and its prospects through that perspective.

Our focus is naturally on those activities that were critical to the direction of immediate post-Independence India. Many became the basis for a cohesive and alternative way of thinking in this country. These expressions of nationalism drove a debate over many decades about the nature of our politics and governance. They also influenced our view about development and progress, including on how best to stand on our own feet. And of course, they shaped our approach to engaging the neighbourhood particularly and the world at large. At one level, each of them may look like a different domain. But the truth is that they represented a holistic worldview, and, in real life, each was inseparable from the other.

The question that is most deeply associated with Mookerjee is that of the accession of Jammu & Kashmir and the ensuing debate about that process and its implications. His position is, of course, summed up by the famous slogan: '*Ek Desh mein do Vidhan, do pradhan, do nishan, nahi chalenge* [There cannot be two Constitutions, two PMs and two flags in one nation].' In Parliament and outside, Mookerjee brought up concerns of balkanization and the weakening of the Indian polity as a result. He flagged the implications of contesting sovereignty, claiming competitive status and restricting the display of national symbols. These issues no longer require any further elucidation after so many years and so many experiences. We all know how damaging it has been economically, developmentally, socially and in terms of national security when Jammu & Kashmir were not fully integrated into the mainstream. When that was decisively rectified on 5 August 2019, obviously our national integration emerged that much stronger. But from a foreign-policy perspective, what is worth examining is how this issue was taken advantage of by external powers vis-à-vis India.